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Report: Benton violated state law

But watchdog’s findings leave more questions on Welch’s response to harassment allegations

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A legislative inspector general’s investigatory report released Friday found that disgraced former state Rep. Harry Benton violated state

law by engaging in sexual harassment, and it also revealed the existence of a third female victim, a staffer for another state legislator who said Benton’s “creepy” behavior in a Springfield bar last year made her feel uncomfortable.

But Legislative Inspector

General Michael McCuskey’s report still left unanswered key questions about how Democratic House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch handled allegations first raised by a Benton staffer three years ago. Welch spent \$1.4 million the next year to get Benton, a Democrat from southwest suburban Plainfield, reelected. It was not until a female lobbyist ran into Benton in January in a River North Chicago bar, where

she said he made lewd comments to her, that the speaker’s office took any steps to discipline him.

The seven-page report contains the results of McCuskey’s investigation, which began March 4 following a complaint filed by Welch’s office. It provides a synopsis of many of the details first reported in July by the Tribune, whose monthslong investigation examined Benton’s conduct toward two women — his

former young female staffer and the lobbyist.

But the report also recounts a complaint from a third woman — a legislative district office director who said Benton harassed her in a bar following 2025 Latino Unity Day festivities in Springfield. According to the report, while the female district office director was

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Gray skies, shifting schedules fail to dampen crowd’s spirits at Lollapalooza Day 2 headlined by British pop star Charli xcx, hometown favorites Smashing Pumpkins



IT’S ‘CLOUD AURA’

By Finnegan Belleau, Kate Perez, Jessi Roti and Doug George | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Lollapalooza hit its stride on the Chicago lakefront on Friday and the rain arrived too, with a murky swirl of clouds parking above Grant Park alongside the police helicopters and parade of airplanes towing advertising banners.

Capping the evening, Day 2 main-stage headliners are Charli xcx on the T-Mobile (returning to Chicago on the heels of her famous “Brat” tour last year) and hometown band Smashing Pumpkins on the Bud Light (a set referred to by at least one young festivalgoer as Lollapalooza’s “parents’ night”).

Earlier in the day, the music schedule was in flux Friday, with Paloma Morphy and mainstage draw Lil Uzi Vert dropping out, Slayyter swapping stages with Balu Brigada and other changes — Lollapalooza presenter C3 Presents did not respond to Tribune questions for more information as of press time, but on social media, the festival attributed

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Above: Sir Taegan C'aion Harris, aka Love Spells, performs on Day 2 at Lollapalooza in Chicago’s Grant Park on Friday.
ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Top: People walk through the wet Lollapalooza grounds on Day 2 of the festival. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

DIFFERENT KIND OF WATERWORKS

The last time Lorde was at Lollapalooza, she was no more than two songs in before an emergency weather evacuation for a thunderstorm robbed her and her audience of what surely would’ve been a formidable performance. On Thursday, with not a raindrop in sight, Lorde delivered with emotion and tears.

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■ TikTok is changing how Lollapalooza fans are finding artists. **Page B7**

Deal rests on Israeli pullout in Gaza

Hamas promises to disarm if terms met

By Samy Magdy, Sam Mednick, Jonathan J. Cooper and Matthew Lee
Associated Press

CAIRO — Hamas said Friday that it will begin disarming as part of a deal announced by President Donald Trump that also requires Israel to end its strikes and withdraw from Gaza. It marks a potential breakthrough in ending the war, but implementation faces major challenges.

Hamas also said that laying down its heavy weapons, which would come later in the process, was contingent on the creation of a Palestinian state, something Israel’s current government rejects.

Israel has not officially commented on the deal, which is part of a U.S.-brokered ceasefire announced last October. That agreement called for Hamas to disarm and hand over power to an independent Palestinian administration. Israel was to withdraw, and an International Stabilization Force was to deploy. But progress stalled, with Israel saying everything hinged on Hamas disarming, and Hamas accusing Israel of violating the pact by continuing to carry out regular strikes on Gaza.

Disarming would represent a sea change for Hamas, whose founding charter calls for armed resistance against Israel, and which sees its arsenal, including rockets, anti-tank missiles and explosives, as lying at the heart of its identity.

Israel, meanwhile, appears unlikely to pull back significant forces or make other concessions ahead of its October elections.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu faces a tough reelection battle, with opponents accusing him of failing to prevent the Oct. 7, 2023, attack that triggered the war.

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CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

\$9.96B budget banks on state funds

Fate of layoffs, cuts now in Springfield’s hands

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After a divisive debate, the Chicago Board of Education approved the district’s \$9.96 billion budget Thursday, adopting an amendment that anticipates \$150 million in state funding to reverse school-level cuts.

The district’s 2026-27 budget originally included the layoffs of 760 teachers, department cuts and

a midyear spending freeze to close a \$730 million deficit. The controversial amendment eliminates the spending freeze and plans to undo at least some of the planned layoffs.

But it’s unclear whether additional state funding will materialize.

Lawmakers already passed the state’s budget in June — closing their own \$2 billion deficit — and Chicago Public Schools leaders say they’ve been given no indication that more funding is available.

CPS CEO Macquiline King warned the budget amendment may leave the district vulnerable to midyear school cuts if the money

doesn’t come through. Lenders will also “not look favorably” at unconfirmed revenue, which could lead to credit downgrades and higher borrowing costs, officials said.

“We need to learn from our mistakes instead of repeating them,” King said.

Prior to the vote, CPS Chief Budget Officer Emila Zoko said she would not consider the amended budget balanced as required under state law. She noted that there was no precedent for Springfield allocating new funding for CPS

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Chicago Teachers Union members and Chicago Public Schools lunchroom workers rally as the Board of Education holds a meeting about the budget on Thursday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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